

Morphosyntactic and Referential Properties of Urdu Pronouns: A Preliminary Investigation

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This squib examines the morphosyntactic classification and referential properties of pronouns in Urdu, focusing on personal pronouns, reflexives, and reciprocals. It investigates how these elements interact with Classical Binding Theory (Chomsky 1981), with particular attention to the availability of long-distance binding in Urdu reflexives. The analysis shows that while personal pronouns conform to Binding Condition B and reciprocals obey Condition A, reflexives exhibit behavior that challenges strict locality constraints. Specifically, Urdu reflexives display logophoric properties comparable to those observed in languages such as Icelandic and Japanese. These findings suggest that a discourse-sensitive approach to binding is necessary to adequately account for reflexive interpretation in Urdu.

Classical Binding Theory is intriguingly challenged by Urdu, an Indo-Aryan language spoken mostly in India and Pakistan (Chomsky, 1981). This theory states that pronominals must be free within their governing area (**Condition B**), referential expressions must not be bound at all (**Condition C**), and reflexive pronouns must be bound within a local domain (**Condition A**). Research on South Asian languages indicates notable variations from these norms, even though they apply to English and many Indo-European languages (Reinhart & Reuland, 1993). Specifically, Urdu permits reflexive **long-distance binding (LDB)**, which defies the traditional presumption that anaphors must always be locally bound.

There are two key reasons why studying Urdu pronouns is important. First, it deepens our comprehension of South Asian syntax, namely the relationship between **discourse roles** and reflexive binding. Second, it offers empirical evidence that can be used to improve theoretical models of anaphora resolution and binding, particularly for languages that don't strictly follow location requirements. According to Sigurðsson (1990), if Urdu reflexives have **logophoric qualities**—that is, if they can refer to a discourse-related perspective-holder instead of being strictly locally bound—then Binding Theory needs to be adjusted to incorporate **discourse-sensitive limitations**.

To demonstrate how Urdu reflexives contradict Classical Binding Theory, take a look at the following instances. The reflexive *apne āp* ('oneself') functions as anticipated in a local binding situation under Condition A:

1. *Ali| ne| apne āp| ko| dekha.*
Ali| ERG| self|ACC| see.PST
'Ali saw himself.'

Here, *apne āp* must refer to the local subject, Ali (Butt, 1995).

On the other hand, *apne āp* may point to a higher discourse antecedent or the local subject in a long-distance context:

2. *Ali| ne| socha| ki| Ahmed| ne| apne āp| ko| dekha.*
 Ali| ERG| think.PST| that| Ahmed| ERG| self| ACC|
 see.PST ‘Ali thought that Ahmed saw himself.’

In this scenario, *apne āp* can be used to point to Ali (long-distance antecedent) or Ahmed (local subject). According to Sigurðsson (1990), this flexibility implies that Urdu reflexives might not be just syntactic anaphors but rather could have logophoric qualities, in which the antecedent is decided by discourse roles rather than just syntactic locale.

This scenario poses a significant theoretical query: Do Urdu reflexives adhere to discourse-based rules or are they restricted by syntactic locality? In Icelandic (Sigurðsson, 1990) and Japanese (Nishigauchi, 2014), similar LDB phenomena have been noted, where logophoricity—a reliance between an anaphor and a discourse-related antecedent—plays key roles. It would indicate that Binding Theory has to be revised to include discourse-sensitive constraints for non-Indo-European languages if Urdu reflexives show logophoricity.

Urdu personal pronouns, such as *vō*, which means "he/she/it/they," are free within their governing domain, which is required by **Condition B** of Binding Theory (Chomsky, 1981). For example:

3. *Har| larka| sochta| hai| ki| vō| hoshia| hai.*
 every| boy| think.PRS| be| he.3.SG| smart| be
 ‘Every boy thinks that he is smart.’

In this case, *vō* ('he') can be constrained by a quantifier, confirming that it is a **pronominal** and not an anaphor. This implies that reflexives differ greatly from personal pronouns and reciprocals, which both adhere to normal binding criteria.

In Urdu, reciprocals (*ek dūsre ko*, ‘each other’) must have a local plural antecedent in order to strictly follow **Condition A**:

4. *Larkōn| ne| ek dūsre| ko| dekha.*
 boys| ERG| one other| ACC|
 see.PST ‘The boys saw each other.’

This adherence to Condition A implies that the standard locality limitations of Binding Theory are only challenged by reflexives in Urdu.

Two major hypotheses are supported by the actions of Urdu reflexives. First, Urdu reflexives are not only locally restricted but also **logophoric**, meaning they can refer to discourse-based antecedents. The second is that long-distance binding is only available if the antecedent is a **perspective-holder**, like the subject of a verb of speech (*kehna*, "to say") or thinking (*sochna*, "to think").

5. *Ali| ne| dekha| ki| Ahmed| ne| apne āp| ko| dekha.*
 Ali| ERG| see.PST| that| Ahmed| ERG| self| ACC| see.PST
 ‘Ali saw that Ahmed saw himself.’

Here, *dekha* ('saw') does not establish a perspective-holder, therefore in this case, *apne āp* can only relate to Ahmed. Instead of being solely syntactic domains, this restriction implies that discourse roles mediate long-distance reflexive binding in Urdu.

These results suggest that in order to accommodate **discourse-sensitive constraints** in languages such as Urdu, Binding Theory needs to be extended. Urdu would be in line with other languages like **Icelandic** and **Japanese**, where logophoric pronouns are sensitive to the antecedent's perspective, if reflexives are in fact logophoric (Nishigauchi, 2014). Moreover, the fact that personal pronouns and reciprocals in Urdu conform to Conditions B and A, respectively, while reflexives deviate, suggests a need for a **nuanced binding framework** that differentiates between purely syntactic and discourse- based anaphors.

Future studies should concentrate on two main areas: (1) determining if **logophoricity** and **long-distance binding** patterns are similar in other South Asian languages, and (2) gathering **experimental evidence** on how native speakers understand reflexives in various discourse circumstances. Such studies could improve theoretical models of binding that take **cross-linguistic variation** into account and offer more insights into the relationship between syntax and discourse in anaphora resolution.

References

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